

Episode 140: *The Tatami Galaxy* Colour Design Notes Volume 1

Sports Day long weekend—some schools probably had athletic festivals around this time. In elementary school, I absolutely hated those "rehearsals" done the day before athletic festivals—I just couldn't stand them. Why practises everything? Is doing things properly that important? One-shot showdowns would be fine! And such.

Well, looking back at this age, that's right—there's no way things would go well in one shot (laugh). Not just running, but ball toss, tug-of-war, plus various dances—there were quite procedurally demanding competitive events. If I were an elementary school teacher, I'd be so nervous I might make them rehearse two or three times (laugh).

"Come to think of it, why were boys so reluctant to hold hands during folk dancing at middle school sports festivals?" came up at a drinking party with female colleagues sometime. "Right right, just barely touching fingertip to fingertip (laugh)." Man, we were embarrassed—what adolescence!

"Now we'd totally hold hands firmly!" The female colleagues' strong words made perfect sense (laugh).

Now then.

Continuing from last time, "*The Tatami Galaxy* Colour Design Notes." Finally individual episode notes.

Episode 1: Tennis Club "Cupid"

Storyboard & Direction: Yuasa Masaaki, Animation Director: Ito Nobuyoshi, Colour Direction: Tsujita Kunio

As usual, I request to handle colour direction for TV series first episodes myself, and this time too I did everything for Episode 1 myself.

Episode 1 work featured many locations appearing throughout the series, so rather than Episode 1-specific, it was work while solidifying visual policies and foundations for the entire series. For example, opening cat ramen cart scene and Kiyamachi fortune-teller granny scene were decided as fixed imagery throughout the entire series. Cat ramen cart added yellow tones to normal characters matching background-painted yellow lighting, and Kiyamachi granny was built from the start on red backgrounds.

The four-and-a-half tatami room that would become stage centre was decided through director and art consultation as "dim during day, brightest when lights are on at night." So characters in lit nighttime four-and-a-half tatami were set in basic "normal" colours. Therefore, the latter B-part castella-eating scene became the only "normal" colour direction scene in Episode 1.

Other scenes were designed matching scene-specific art boards. Consecutive Kamogawa Delta fireworks scenes and "Gozan" bridge scenes were decided based on night brightness-darkness balance, yakiniku restaurant scenes added yellow-green matching background colours. Since only "I" is drunk, above the neck is pink, but completion-wise it was somewhat weak? So for similar scenes from Episode 2 onward, I decided to adjust redness much stronger.

"It's a promise, right?" flashback scene evening—including art, making outlines (main lines) orange was the director's decision, so I first set main lines in colours matching art board main lines, then adjusted colours to match art boards. Initially starting from fairly normal-like colours, "How about boldly making hair orange too?" suggested the director. So boldly trying it, it became that orange.

However, Akashi-san's bag, which was black like hair—following rules it would also become orange, but there's a cut explaining the five-coloured "mochiguma" hanging from the bag (actually four colours since one is missing), and so viewers would have

"mochiguma" clearly impressed upon them, I deliberately kept the bag behind those "mochiguma" blackish.

Final "Gozan" crowd scene. All characters except main ones got bold single-colour silhouette processing, but those colour tones and brightness were indeed subtle—they combined nicely on computer monitors, but watching actually shot cuts on checking monitors showed poor balance. Main lines dissolved into painting colours or dissolved against backgrounds. So I requested several retakes (reshoots) for subtle cut-by-cut adjustments.

Episode 2: Film Club "Misogi"

Storyboard & Direction: Yokoyama Akitoshi, Animation Director: Nishigaki Shoko, Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

As with *Casshern Sins*, I was entrusted with colour direction staff selection and rotation control this time too, so I contacted acquaintance colour direction staff for participation. This time basically three colour direction staff rotation. I handled Episodes 1 and final 11, with remaining nine episodes split three each among three people.

Weekly delivery TV series schedules have biweekly crunches for dubbing coordination and master coordination. Handling this with two people often creates situations where crunch periods for consecutive episodes overlap. With three people, at least one non-crunch week occurs. Since everyone carries other project work too, creating some leeway somewhere is essential—when exhausted during crucial times, it's hard to produce strength.

Top batter was Akimoto-san. I kept showing her Episode 1 footage approaching completion to grasp atmosphere while watching. From then, Episodes 3 and 4 similarly kept showing advanced episode footage for reference.

The big point from Episode 2 onward was "flashback" and "present." Episode 2+ stories had "I" standing at certain points, first half "flashbacking" to events leading there, second half being developments from "present" where "I" stands. "A look that makes you think 'ah, this is flashback'" said the director. So I conceived making both art and cels use sepia-tone brown main line colours, with colour tones also consciously brown-sepia to match. Character clothing also changes between present and past. So main locations also had two normal colour direction types: regular "normal colour" and "flashback normal colour." Skin colours stayed the same, but parts that were data "black (BL)" like hair in regular "normal colour" were all replaced with "grey-system dark brown" matching backgrounds' darkest colours in "flashback normal colour."

Like that, basically all special painting scene by scene. It seemed quite complex and confusing, so from this episode I started writing "colour charts" mentioned briefly last time. This made colour direction meetings, explanations, and actual work much smoother.

Oh right, Yoshida Mountain flashback scene. "Where exactly is my skin white? There are lots of other people with white skin..." Akashi-san's line. While wanting to retort "No no Akashi-san, you're plenty white," actually Akashi-san's skin colour had faint redness, and RGB data-wise "I" had whiter skin. I couldn't help grinning alone (laugh).

Bonus: Opening

Storyboard & Direction: Yuasa Masaaki, Video Design & Photography & Editing: Kato Michiya, Colour Direction: Tsujita Kunio

For this opening's colours, I handled everything myself. Not just appearing character colours, but background colour tone conversion, text colours, live-action movie colour tone balance—everything. Being entrusted with everything like this was my first experience—very enjoyable and educational.

Based on imagery conveyed in meetings, I prepared data in advance, then matching it to provisional movies sent by Kato-san, while somewhat restraining the director who was tired from daily storyboard checks and meetings, I decided everything one by one—not just colours but timing of colour changes and how many times to change.

Characters spinning at opening's end—when we started making the opening many characters still had unconfirmed colours, so it took until delivery deadline with 2-3 replacements to reach final version colours.

(10.10.12)